1 **merchant** [ˈmɜːtʃənt] *n.* — торговец, купец
A person who buys things and sells them again.
→ The merchant sells silk in every town on the road.

2 **cook** [kʊk] *n.* — повар
A person whose job is to make food.
→ The cook makes soup for forty men every day.

3 **servant** [ˈsɜːvənt] *n.* — слуга
A person who works in the house of a rich family.
→ Two servants carried the bags into the room.

4 **silk** [sɪlk] *n.* — шёлк
A soft and expensive cloth.
→ Her dress was made of blue silk.

5 **prove** [pruːv] *v.* — доказать
To show that something is true.
→ You say it is your bicycle. Please prove it.

6 **thief** [θiːf] *n.* — вор
A person who takes things that are not his.
→ The thief opened the window very quietly.

7 **tent** [tent] *n.* — палатка
A small house made of cloth. You sleep in it outside.
→ We put our tent near the river and made a fire.

8 **pot** [pɒt] *n.* — кастрюля, котелок
A deep round dish. You cook food in it over a fire.
→ There is hot soup in the big black pot.

9 **tail** [teɪl] *n.* — хвост
The long part at the back of an animal.
→ When my dog is happy, his tail never stops.

10 **steal** [stiːl] *v.* — красть, воровать
To take something that is not yours.
→ Somebody stole my pen, and I know who it was.

11 **trick** [trɪk] *n.* — хитрость, трюк
A clever thing that you do to win, or to find the truth.
→ It was a simple trick, but it worked.

Useful phrases from the story

do your best — сделать всё, что можешь
I cannot promise, but I will do my best.

keep a secret — хранить секрет
Can you keep a secret? Do not tell anybody.

run away — убежать
The little boy ran away when he saw the big dog.

The Donkey That Knew the Thief

A rich **merchant** named Rustam stopped for the night at a house on the mountain road. He had ten men with him: a **cook**, two drivers and seven **servants**. He also had a bag of gold and two pieces of **silk**.

In the morning the gold was gone.

Rustam was angry. “Somebody in this house has taken my gold,” he shouted, “and I know who it is. It is the boy.”

The boy was Karim. He carried the water and washed the pots, and he was the poorest person there. Everybody turned and looked at him.

“I did not take it,” Karim said quietly. “Then **prove** it,” Rustam said.

“I will **do my best**,” Karim said. He thought for a long time. “Wait until tonight. Tonight the **thief** will show himself to all of us.”

That evening Karim put a small **tent** in the yard, and he put the old donkey inside it. His name was Bobo, and he was the laziest animal on that road. Karim also took the black cooking **pot** off the fire and carried it into the **tent**. Then he closed the door.

“Bobo is a magic donkey,” Karim told the men. “You will all go in, one by one, in the dark. You will put your hand on his **tail** and say these words: I did not **steal** the gold. Bobo knows the truth about every man here. When the **thief** touches him, Bobo will cry out, and everybody in the yard will hear it.”

Some of the men laughed. Some of them did not laugh at all. “Nobody may **run away**,” Rustam said. “Every man goes in.”

One by one they walked into the dark **tent**, and one by one they came out again. Bobo ate his grass and made no sound.

Rustam smiled a cold smile. “Your magic does not work, boy. Now we will talk about you again.” “One moment,” Karim said. “Please show me your hands. All of you.”

Ten men held up their hands. Nine pairs of hands were black from the fingers to the arm. One pair was clean and white. They were the hands of the **cook**.

“He never touched Bobo,” Karim said. “He was the only man in this yard who believed me. The **tail** is black, because I put the bottom of that **pot** on it before you came.”

The **cook** looked at his clean hands for a long time. Then he told them where the gold was. Rustam gave Karim two silver coins and a piece of **silk**. “Do not tell this to other people,” he said. “**Keep it a secret**.”

Karim did not keep it a secret. He told it in every village on that road, so now the **trick** is finished and it will never work again. And Bobo is still standing in the same yard, eating the same grass, and he has never said one word about any of it.

